

Practice Paper 40 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “Habit has a longer memory than the body”

1 mark for understanding that the narrator’s **physical body** has stopped doing the work but his **ingrained routines** have not.

1 mark for explaining the **image**: his hand keeps reaching for letters that are not there because thirty-one years of repeated action have left a memory that lasts longer than the working life itself.

Q2. [2] — “Known the road first by its dogs”

1 mark — He came to recognise houses not by their numbers or owners but by the **animals** and **small distinctive features** attached to them.

1 mark — This suggests an **intimate, observational** knowledge of the neighbourhood, built up **slowly and through daily presence**, rather than a formal or abstract one.

Q3. [1] — Time has passed

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- Pip the spaniel “had been gone for nine years now”.
- The Labrador “had outlived the Bensons themselves”.
- The implication that several pets and owners have died since his working days.

Q4. [2] — “Redecorated in my absence”

1 mark — **Feeling**: The phrase suggests the changes are **cosmetic / surface-level**; the street is **fundamentally the same place** it always was, and so the narrator does not feel alienated or upset by them — he feels gently **acknowledged** by it.

1 mark — **Detail** (any one):

- The hedge at number twenty-three has been pulled out and replaced by a low brick wall.

- The squealing gate at number thirty-one has been replaced by a smart aluminium one.
- The peeling green door at number forty-five has been repainted charcoal.

Q5. [2] — The old woman's recognition

(a) [1]: It suggests she **vaguely recognises** the narrator but has to **search her memory carefully** to place him; she has not seen him for some time, and the recognition is **slow and effortful**.

(b) [1]: It is significant because **no one has called him "Mr Aldridge" for two years** — to be addressed by his old working name reconnects him, briefly, to his professional identity / former role as postman.

Q6. [3] — Ordinary work, important to others

1 mark for identifying the **contrast** — the narrator views the work as mundane while the woman treats it as memorable and meaningful.

1 mark each for any **two** details, quoted and explained (max 2):

- "the daily business of getting paper from one hand into another" — the phrasing reduces letter-delivery to a trivial mechanical task.
- "there must have been four hundred such small arrangements" — the word "small" and the large number suggest he saw each as too minor to remember.
- "to me they had been only" — the word "only" diminishes the importance he attached to such favours.
- "She remembered. I, in honest truth, did not." — the blunt contrast emphasises that what was forgettable to him was treasured by her.
- The woman remembers the Christmas card from her grandson "year after year" — for her the arrangement was deeply important.

Q7. [2] — "A thin, daily thread"

1 mark — The image of a **thread** suggests he was a **small but essential connection** — barely noticed, but the means by which separate houses were **linked** to one another and to the outside world.

1 mark — "**Daily**" emphasises that this connection was **constant and reliable**; he held the neighbourhood together quietly, without ceremony, simply by appearing each morning.

Q8. [1] — Repetition of "useful"

1 mark — The repetition suggests the narrator is **holding on to the word / testing it for weight**; he is recognising, perhaps for the first time, that his **modest, unglamorous work** genuinely **mattered** to others, and he takes a quiet pride in it. (Also accept: emphasis through repetition.)

Q9. [1] — Evidence of reflective mood

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- He **stops walking** and sits down on the bench.
- He **thinks of "all the doors I had once approached without thinking"**.
- He thinks of the lives **"polite and unremarkable" behind each door**.

- He notes the man's wave — perhaps to him, perhaps to the day itself — suggesting contemplative attention.

Q10. [2] — Two kinds of emptiness

1 mark — **Emptiness of having delivered everything:** the **active, working** emptiness of a bag at the end of a shift — a sense of **task completed**, of duty discharged for the day.

1 mark — **The gentler emptiness of having nothing left to deliver:** the **quieter, retired** emptiness of having **finished altogether** — there is no more work waiting, only acceptance and peace.

Q11. [1] — Tone of final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, affectionate, gently humorous, contented, warm.** (Reject: **sad, bitter** — these miss the quiet contentment.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “World of spy thrillers”

1 mark — It suggests the technology was once considered **fictional** / **imaginary**, the stuff of **films and novels** rather than real life.

1 mark — It also suggests the technology felt **exotic, futuristic and slightly sinister** — something exciting on screen but not expected in everyday public spaces.

Q13. [2] — Benefits to ordinary citizens

1 mark each for any two of:

- Phones **unlock on a glance**.
- Banking apps **confirm identity without a password**.
- Entry to one’s own apartment becomes a matter of **walking up to the door**.

Reject: airport queues / police investigations — these are not “ordinary citizen” benefits.

Q14. [2] — Purpose of “to dismiss the technology outright...”

1 mark — To establish the writer’s **balance and fairness** — he is **not anti-technology**, and he wants the reader to trust him before he begins criticising it.

1 mark — To **pre-empt the accusation** that the article will be one-sided, and to make the criticisms that follow **more persuasive** by showing they come from a measured commentator.

Q15. [2] — “Fail in ways that are far from random”

1 mark — The errors are **not evenly distributed** across the population; certain groups suffer mistakes far more often than others.

1 mark — Specifically, **women and people with darker skin** are **misidentified at much higher rates** — so the failures **follow existing patterns of disadvantage**.

Q16. [1] — Real-world consequence

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- **Several men in the United States have been wrongfully arrested** due to misidentification.
- **All of those men, so far, have been Black** (showing the bias has real victims).
- The 2019 NIST study found **error rates ten times higher** for some groups.

Q17. [2] — Airport traveller vs public-square pedestrian

1 mark — A **traveller** in an airport has, in some sense, **chosen** to be scanned: passing through the gate is an **active decision** that implies consent.

1 mark — A **pedestrian** in a public square has **made no such choice**; she has merely **gone outside**, yet is scanned, matched and logged **without her knowledge or agreement**.

Q18. [2] — “A partner she cannot see, on terms she has not read”

1 mark — The language of “**partner**” and “**terms**” borrows from **contract law**, making clear that surveillance is a kind of **agreement** — except this one is being entered into **invisibly and silently**.

1 mark — “**She cannot see**” and “**she has not read**” emphasise her complete **ignorance and powerlessness**; she is a party to a deal she cannot inspect, which is the opposite of fair consent.

Q19. [2] — “Enormous unplanned experiment”

1 mark each for any two of:

- The EU has **banned most live facial recognition** under the AI Act 2024.
- Several **American cities** (San Francisco, Boston, Portland) have **prohibited it** for police use.
- **China** has built a network of more than **half a billion cameras** tied to social-credit systems.
- **Singapore** has taken a **middle path**, deploying it selectively with scrutiny.
- Different countries are reaching **opposite conclusions** with little international coordination.

Q20. [2] — “Innocents” vs “suspects waiting to be cleared”

1 mark — The contrast **reverses the usual presumption**: instead of being **assumed innocent** until proven guilty, every citizen is treated as a **potential suspect** whose innocence must be confirmed.

1 mark — The phrasing exposes how surveillance **changes the relationship between citizen and state** — a watched society is one in which **freedom is conditional**, granted only after clearance, not assumed by right.

Q21. [1] — Tone of final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **cautiously hopeful, urgent, resolute, measured, empowering**. (Reject: **pessimistic, despairing** — these miss the call to action.)

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Problems with facial-recognition technology (Paragraphs 3–4):

1. The systems are **much less accurate** than their marketing claims.
2. Errors fall **disproportionately on women** and on **darker-skinned faces** (built-in bias).
3. The errors have caused **real harm** — innocent people, in particular Black men in the United States, have been **wrongfully arrested**.
4. People in **public spaces have not consented** to being scanned, unlike a traveller passing through an airport gate.
5. Surveillance is **inappropriate to the context** — pedestrians do not know they are part of a transaction.

How regulators have responded (Paragraph 5):

6. The **European Union** has banned most live facial recognition in public spaces under its 2024 AI Act.
7. **Several US cities** (San Francisco, Boston, Portland) have prohibited its use by police.

8. **China** has embraced it, building a network of over half a billion cameras tied to social-credit systems; **Singapore** takes a middle path with parliamentary scrutiny.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

One major problem with facial-recognition technology is that it is far less accurate than claimed, misidentifying women and darker-skinned faces at much higher rates, and has already led to wrongful arrests. People in public spaces are also scanned without consent. Regulators disagree sharply: the European Union has banned most live use, several American cities prohibit it for police, China has embraced it through vast camera networks, while Singapore deploys it selectively under parliamentary oversight.

Length count: 78 words from “One” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —